multiple Holy Books. Withal, like Christianity and Islam, Marxism is a faith whose practice is very heavily determined by its texts. Thus Communists the world over justify their actions on the basis of this or that passage in the works of Marx, Engels, Lenin or Mao.

It was the philosopher Alasdair MacIntyre who first drew attention to the parallels between a professedly secular belief system and a religious doctrine. In a book called *Marxism and Christianity* (originally published in 1953, and reissued in an expanded edition fifteen years later), MacIntyre observed that ‘creedal uniformity, as in religion, often seems to be valued by Marxists for its own sake’. He further pointed out that this secular creed, like its religious counterpart, endowed its adherents with an emancipatory role denied to individuals who believed in more humdrum ideologies. To quote MacIntyre, ‘both Marxism and Christianity rescue individual lives from the insignificance of finitude … by showing the individual that he has or can have some role in a world-historical drama’. In this, Marxism and Christianity are akin to one another, and to Islam, whose devoted or dogmatic adherents likewise believe that their life, and death, find meaning and fulfilment in a pleasure-filled and enemy-free Utopia.

II

The text I shall here subject to scrutiny—the technical term may be ‘exegesis’—was written not by Marx or Lenin, but by a *desi* deity so to say. One of the most influential of all Indian Marxists, his name was Balchandra Triambak Ranadive. He was known as ‘BTR’, these initials whispered with respect, or might we say reverence, by party members past and present.

The text that I am going to resurrect was written in 1978, a year after a Left Front government dominated by the CPI(M) came to power in the large and crucial state of West Bengal. It took the shape of an extended review of a book by the Spanish Communist Santiago Carrillo entitled *Eurocommunism and the State*. The review was published over thirty-three closely printed pages of *Social Scientist*, a Marxist monthly edited by